transpired so far and inquiring if he would like to speak. But after a very brief apology for the interruption that he had caused, Bush requested that we continue from where we had left off.

So here I was, barely weeks into my new position as governor, speaking not just for India but for all emerging markets, telling the President of the US and his team of the obligations advanced economies, particularly the US, had towards emerging markets. I was quite satisfied with my intervention; I thought it came out quite cogently and effectively, given my limited experience and even more limited preparation.

President Bush then said that he had already been briefed about the US situation, but wanted to get a first-hand account of Europe. So the ECB president, Trichet, got an opportunity to repeat what he had said earlier.

Bush spoke after that. He spoke informally, but with self-assurance. I can't recall all of what he said but one point he made stayed in my mind. He reiterated his conviction that in the American system of free enterprise, markets should be unfettered and the federal government should intervene only when necessary. He said he had agonized quite a lot over the previous few weeks whether the nature and extent of government intervention in the financial markets was the right thing to do. But the precarious nature of the financial markets post-Lehman—and importantly, the impact of that on the daily lives of the American people—had led him to believe that such intervention was not only warranted but even essential. Echoing the approach taken by Franklin D. Roosevelt in the years following the Great Depression, he added that preserving the free market in the long run occasionally required government intervention in the short run. Finally, he added that he was confident that the ministers and governors gathered around the table were more than equal to the challenge of resolving the growing market turmoil.

Bush then looked at his watch, apologized once again for his unscheduled appearance, apologized also that he couldn't stay longer since he had promised 'Laura' that he would be back home for dinner. As he started walking back the way he entered, all of us stood up; he exchanged a few words with Trichet, said something to Bernanke and acknowledged a